

Dr Robert Harlow

Plymouth, UK

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Professional Summary

Cognitive psychologist specialising in autism, neuroscience and public engagement. Experienced designing and managing behavioural research projects, communicating complex evidence to diverse audiences, and collaborating across healthcare, education and research settings. Skilled in stakeholder engagement, complex data analytics, and robust research practices, with a strong record of building trusted relationships, research management, and leading collaborative projects end-to-end. A passionate researcher and science communicator with specialisms in robust and inclusive practices.

Core Competencies

Patient & Public Involvement

- Participatory engagement with neurodivergent and vulnerable populations.
- Inclusive communication and accessible information design.
- Contributed to PPIE meetings and advisory discussions with external stakeholders, including local NHS partnerships.

Research & Evaluation

- Lead experimental design and behavioural research at PhD level using expert knowledge.
- Mixed-methods data interpretation from interviews to psychometrics across multiple studies.
- Quantitative analysis skills of complex datasets (SPSS, R, Matlab, Jamovi, OpenSesame).
- Qualitative analysis skills of sensitive interview data using thematic analysis.
- Specialist Motion Capture, EEG, and fNIRS neuroscience data acquisition and analysis.
- Conducted ethical applications and governance compliance for multiple projects.

Stakeholder & Community Engagement

- Led public science communication to 145k+ audience, including in-person presentations.
- Liaise with local authorities, community groups, and emergency stakeholders.
- Provided teaching in further education and SEN environments.
- Conducted conference presentations of complex knowledge to non-experts.

Leadership

- Director of a Community Interest Company (UK Weather Chase – 16977806).
- Local Network Lead for UKRN (Open Science) to promote robust research practices.
- Research project management end-to-end during both PhD and 2 x post-doc RA roles.

Professional Experience

Postdoctoral Researcher x2 - University of Plymouth | Oct/Nov 2025 – Present

- Contribute to two autism-focused neuroscience projects using EEG + fNIRS brain scanning.
- Performed, analysed, and interpreted multiple psychometrics for all participants across multiple studies, including AQ, SPQ, GAD-7, CATI, and PHQ-9.
- Coordinated research activities across multiple stakeholders, helping deliver complex neuroscience studies on schedule.
- Engaged in PPIE meetings to discuss inclusive research practice and project application.
- Successfully recruited and supported autistic participants through inclusive research practices, contributing to high-quality participant retention and community ties.

PhD Researcher – Predictive Perception in Autism - University of Plymouth | 2022 – 2025

- End-to-end management of complex experimental research projects.
- Recruited 486 people over multiple scientific studies, 120 being autistic people.
- Maintained ethical research practices throughout study design and implementation.
- Strategized open science initiatives for transparent and replicable research designs.
- Presented at 3 national and 2 international conferences, attended many others.
- Supervised and marked on undergraduate and postgraduate modules to teach complex topics.

Behavioural Teaching Assistant (SEN School) - Linwood School | 2020 – 2022

- Supported autistic and ADHD students in academic and social development.
- Adapted communication styles to meet diverse cognitive and emotional needs.
- Collaborated with teachers, support staff, and families to support inclusive practice.

Independent Custody Visitor- Office of the Police and Crime Commissioner (Dorset) | 2019 – 2022

- Conducted independent welfare visits to police custody suites.
- Interviewed detainees in their cells to ensure safeguarding and rights compliance.
- Reported observations to oversight bodies, contributing to public accountability.
- Conducted a qualitative interview-based research project with the OPCC and Bournemouth University to help improve the custody process for detainees.

Leadership & Public Engagement**Director – UK Weather Chase (CIC) Management 2023 – Present. Director: Jan 2026 - Present**

- Lead a science-based CIC providing severe weather forecasting and public guidance.
- Analyse complex models to inform risk assessment and deployment decisions for extreme weather events.
- Communicate complex scientific data to 140,000+ people via digital platforms.
- Liaise with local authorities and emergency stakeholders to support public safety.
- Oversee responsible risk communication and public engagement strategies.

Academic & Professional Service

- Local Network Lead for the UK Reproducibility Network, promoting transparent, high-quality research practices and coordinating researcher engagement across the university.
- Organiser – ReproducibiliTea journal club promoting research transparency
- Conference host – School of Psychology Research Conference (2023).
- Presented at multiple national and international conferences.
- Membership of the Experimental Psychology Society (2022 – ongoing).

Education

- PhD Psychology - University of Plymouth (2025)
- MSc Investigative Forensic Psychology (2019)
- BA (Hons) Human Behavioural Studies (2018)
- FdA Counselling Studies (2017)

Publications

- Harlow, R., Biggs, H., Bach, P. *et al.* You still intend to move: Inferred mental states imply motion to static body postures. *Psychon Bull Rev* **33**, 213 (2026). <https://doi.org/10.3758/s13423-026-02993-6>
- Harlow, R., Marsden, J., Bach, P. *et al.* Predictive Social Perception and Double Empathy: Autistic Disclosure Affects Action Understanding by Non-Autistic Observers. *Autism*. (under review) (2026).
- 2 further autism focused manuscript publications currently under submission.